

Windows XP Media Center Edition

A year after the launch of Windows XP, Microsoft released the Windows XP Media Center Edition, which aimed to turn the home computer into a full entertainment solution. It's basically Windows XP Professional, with the addition of new software—Media Center. Media Center turned your computer into a remote-controlled TV, DVD Player and music system. It also lets you record video from the TV to your hard disk. Now, you can 'pause' live TV by recording it to your hard drive when you need to make that important trip to the kitchen but don't want to miss any part of the news.



The Windows XP Media Center

Media Center can only offer all these capabilities on a mean machine, and so Microsoft decided it wasn't wise to sell it as a separate retail version, should someone try to run it on a lower-end PC. They only distribute it to computer builders, and to own Media Center you need to buy a PC that comes loaded with it.

Media Center 2005, released in October 2004, requires at least a 1.6 GHz processor, DirectX 9-compatible video hardware such as ATI's Radeon or nVidia's GeForce, and 256 MB of RAM at a bare minimum.

Other Editions of Windows XP

With Intel releasing new 64-bit processors such as the Itanium, Microsoft decided to release a new edition of Windows XP, called Windows XP 64-bit Edition. It was designed to exploit the abilities of both Intel's and AMD's newest processors. It started out with little support for multimedia applications, but this was addressed in its later versions.